

Enhancing Australia's environmental biosecurity is the responsibility of the Australian Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer (ACEBO).

On this page, learn how the ACEBO is working to improve environmental biosecurity outcomes.

Australian Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer

The ACEBO is responsible for improving Australia's capacity to manage environmental biosecurity risks. They provide national strategic direction and policy advice on environmental biosecurity issues.

The ACEBO is the point of contact for national reporting of environmental pests, diseases and weeds under the [National Environmental Biosecurity Response Agreement \(NEBRA\)](#). They ensure clear Commonwealth leadership during [environmental responses](#).

Dr Gabrielle Vivian-Smith



Dr Gabrielle Vivian Smith was appointed as the Australian Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer in 2026.

She has more than 20 years' experience in biosecurity, leading complex scientific, policy and operational programs at both state and national levels.

Dr Vivian Smith previously served as the Australian Chief Plant Protection Officer (2021–2026) and as Victoria's Chief Plant Health Officer (2013–2017). Before that, she led a range of Queensland Government biosecurity programs from 2001 to 2013, including invasive species research, policy and operational work.

Her qualifications include a Bachelor of Agricultural Science (Hons), a Graduate Diploma in Horticulture, and a PhD in Ecology.

History of the ACEBO

In 2012, Commonwealth and mainland state and territory governments signed an agreement to work together to create a more effective biosecurity system. This was known as the Intergovernmental Agreement on Biosecurity (IGAB). This led to the establishment of the [National Biosecurity Committee](#) and the [National Environmental Biosecurity Response Agreement \(NEBRA\)](#).

There was an independent review of the agreement in 2017. The review recommended a greater focus on environmental biosecurity. The ACEBO role was established to help protect Australia's environment and way of life from exotic pests and diseases.

Office of the Chief Environment Biosecurity Officer

The department's Office of the Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer (OCEBO) supports ACEBO in strengthening Australia's biosecurity system.

OCEBO is a new division that includes Environmental Biosecurity Policy and Strategy, Invasive Species Research and Development, Invasive Species National Coordination and the [Australian Plague Locust Commission](#).

The office works across 3 priority areas.

Preparedness and response

OCEBO helps prepare for incursions of exotic environmental pests by analysing global trends and prioritising risks. We provide advice on Australia's preparedness efforts and manage the [Exotic Environmental Pest List](#), which assists with our preparedness and response activities.

Coordination, education and engagement

The office raises awareness of the importance of environmental biosecurity through [webinars](#) and other engagement activities. [We work in partnership with governments and environmental groups](#) through committees and forums. We coordinate and fund management activities for high priority established pest animals. Our programs support communities to develop better solutions to combat pest animals and weeds. We work in partnership with First Nations peoples.

Research and innovation

We look for new ways of working that improve Australia's environmental biosecurity system. To ensure our decisions are based on the best available science, we partner with the nation's leading research organisations. Through our [Environmental Biosecurity Project Fund](#), we are investing in innovation that builds capability within the biosecurity system.

With the Biosecurity RD&E Cross-Strategy Working Group, we developed a factsheet - How the National Biosecurity RD&E Strategies Work Together: A Guide for Researchers & Funders.

How the National Biosecurity RD&E Strategies Work Together: A Guide for Researchers & Funders

This factsheet has been created to bring together Australia's four national biosecurity RD&E strategies to help researchers focus on key priorities and funders to invest strategically in the priority areas.

Key activities

Current projects and programs include:

- Environmental Biosecurity Project Fund

The Environmental Biosecurity Project Fund (EBPF) supports

[research, innovation and public education projects](#) that help protect Australia from exotic environmental pests, weeds and diseases.

- The Exotic Environmental Pest List

The

[Exotic Environmental Pest List](#) contains 168 pest species that could cause significant environmental damage if they were to establish in Australia.

- Carp Biological Control Program

Work is underway to assess the potential to

[use the carp virus to control carp](#) in Australia.

- Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza preparation

The OCEBO supports the

[National HPAI Preparedness Taskforce](#) to assist with preparing for the possible arrival of [Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/environmental/acebo>